desires, but he considered that such attachments were possible only when freedom was possible.[12]

It was, however, Professor Jaichandra Vidyalankar who had the biggest impact on Bhagat Singh. A teacher of the history of India, he was particularly concerned with the effect of the Rowlatt Committee Report, which paved the way to the extension of the powers of the viceroy's government in dealing with sedition through the censorship of the press and the detention of political activists without trial, as well as in the effectiveness of the non-cooperation movement in the struggle for freedom. This would have surprised no one, as not only was he an author of two history books himself but he also acted as a conduit between the students of National College and leading revolutionaries outside. He had the credentials to do so. Bhagat Singh had met his fellow revolutionary, Sachindra Nath Sanyal, at his house in 1922 for the first time. Juneja describes Sanyal as 'the political guru of Bhagat Singh'.[13] Others in rival revolutionary outfits, such as the Ghadar Party, were only too aware of this. This is why attempts were made to wean Bhagat Singh away from Sanyal. They were singularly unsuccessful. One person who tried to do so was the stalwart Sikh Ghadri Baba, Gurmukh Singh. In 1914 he had boarded the Komagata Maru to head off to Canada only to be prevented from landing because of Canada's all-white policy. Over 300 passengers met with the same fate. The forlorn ship had no option but to return to India. Upon arrival at Budge Budge Ghat in Calcutta, the police attacked the defenceless passengers, firing upon them without provocation. Gurmukh Singh managed to escape. He was on the run for three days, only to be arrested and imprisoned in Lahore Central Jail before being tried with others in the First Lahore Conspiracy Case in 1915. He was sentenced to imprisonment in the Andamans but managed to escape yet again after jumping from a moving train as it was taking the prisoners to their destination. He eventually found sanctuary in Kabul.

With such a strong pedigree, one would have thought that Gurmukh Singh was entitled to warn Bhagat Singh that unless he escaped from the clutches of the Bengali insurgents he would end up with a noose around his neck and achieve nothing in the process ('*Tum Bengalion ke pher mein mut*